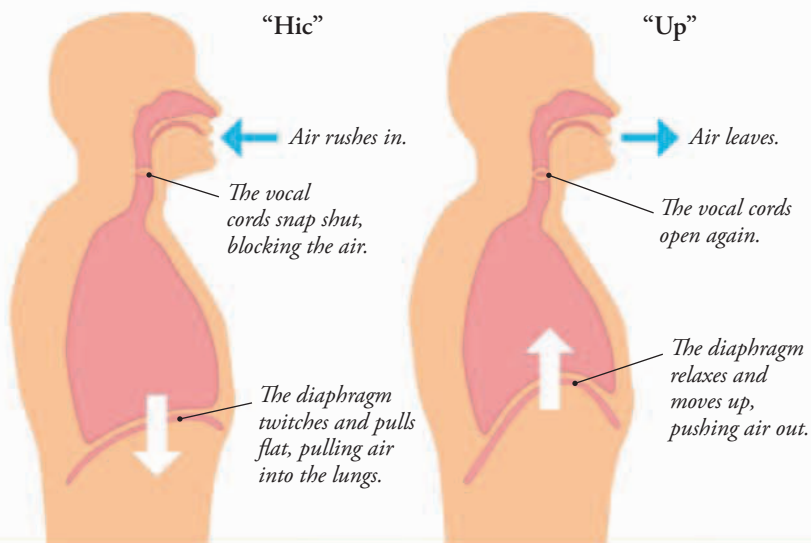


## HICCUPS

Hiccups happen when your diaphragm muscle twitches. The sudden movement of the diaphragm causes a very sharp intake of breath, and the rush of air makes the vocal cords at the top of the trachea snap shut, blocking the air and producing a “hic” sound. Hiccups have no known purpose and can start for no apparent reason. They usually stop after a minute or two, but in rare cases they last longer. One man had a bout of hiccups that lasted 68 years.



## YAWNING

No one knows what purpose yawning serves. Yawns aren't an efficient way of breathing, and although we yawn when we're tired, we also do it when we're nervous. To add to the mystery, yawns are contagious—if you see someone yawn, you'll probably do it too.



## LAUGHING

When we laugh, the vocal cords at the top of the trachea open and close repeatedly, chopping our breaths into segments and making a “ha, ha, ha” or “ho, ho, ho” sound. Laughter triggers the release of brain chemicals called endorphins, which make us feel great.



## SNORING

The roof of your mouth is hard at the front but soft at the back, where it forms a flap of tissue separating your mouth and nose. In some people, this flap wobbles around during sleep, making a loud noise—snoring. People snore less if they lie on one side.



## COUGHING

Coughing gets rid of specks of dirt or germs that have gotten into your airways. First you take a deep breath. Then your lungs squeeze, but the vocal cords stay shut to build up pressure. When they open, air shoots out in a sudden blast.